

There is something hilarious about modern dating.

We have invented enough relationship terminology to fill an entire university course, but somehow people are still standing in front of each other saying, "But we never said we were exclusive," after somebody discovers their partner has been sending another person naked pictures at 1:00 a.m.

Sir.

Please.

Let's talk.

Not because I think everyone should date the same way. I absolutely do not.

Some people want traditional monogamy. Some people date casually. Some people are happily single. Some people are in open relationships. Some people are polyamorous. Some people are exploring and don't know what they want yet.

Fine.

Adults are allowed to build relationships that work for them.

But if we're going to have all these different relationship structures, then perhaps we should actually learn what they mean and, more importantly, learn how to communicate them.

Because I think one of the biggest problems in modern dating isn't that people want different things.

It's that people want different things and then communicate them using deliberately vague language.

MONOGAMY

Monogamy is the traditional arrangement most of us grew up understanding.

You have one romantic and sexual partner at a time.

You date.

You become exclusive.

You build a relationship.

You generally don't sleep with other people, kiss other people, send sexually explicit pictures to other people, go on romantic dates with other people or maintain secret romantic relationships on the side.

Pretty straightforward.

Then there is...

NON-MONOGRAMY

Non-monogamy is the umbrella term for relationships where people aren't restricting themselves to one romantic or sexual connection.

And before somebody starts clutching their pearls, no, non-monogamy does not automatically mean somebody is a horrible person.

People have always had different relationship structures.

The difference now is that we have language for them.

Non-monogamy can include open relationships, polyamory, swinging, relationship anarchy and other consensually negotiated arrangements.

And this is where we need to introduce one very important word.

ETHICAL NON-MONOGRAMY

Ethical non-monogamy, or ENM, basically means that the people involved know what is happening and have consented to it.

That word, ethical, is doing a lot of work.

Because if your partner thinks you are exclusive while you are secretly sleeping with other people, that isn't ethical non-monogamy.

That's cheating.

You don't get to discover the vocabulary of ENM at 27 and suddenly realise you've been cheating ethically.

No.

That's not how this works.

"I'm polyamorous" does not magically transform betrayal into a lifestyle choice.

If the other person didn't know, they didn't consent.

If they didn't consent, you don't get to call it ethical.

POLYAMORY

Polyamory is a form of consensual non-monogamy where someone may have multiple romantic relationships, with the knowledge and consent of the people involved.

And yes, romantic relationships.

That's the part people sometimes forget.

Polyamory isn't simply "I sleep with whoever I want."

You could have multiple partners who all know about one another.

You could have emotional intimacy, romantic commitment, dates, sex and actual relationships with more than one person.

And those relationships don't necessarily look identical.

One person might have a primary partner.

Another person might have several partners without ranking them.

Someone else might be dating people who are also dating other people.

There are different ways of doing it.

The common thread is that the people involved understand the arrangement.

OPEN RELATIONSHIPS

An open relationship is generally a committed relationship where the people involved have agreed that some form of romantic or sexual interaction outside the relationship is allowed.

And even here, there isn't one universal rulebook.

One couple might agree that they can have sex with other people but don't form romantic relationships.

Another might allow dating but have certain boundaries around emotional intimacy.

Another might only allow certain situations.

The point is not that every open relationship looks the same.

The point is that the people in it know what they agreed to.

That is the part that matters.

CASUAL DATING

Then we have casual dating, which is probably where half of modern dating lives.

You like each other.

You go out.

You flirt.

Maybe you sleep together.

Maybe you don't.

Maybe you're seeing other people.

Maybe you're not.

Maybe you're figuring it out.

Casual dating doesn't require a five-year plan.

It does, however, still require basic communication.

And this is where I think we need to address something that people seem determined to make unnecessarily complicated.

SO, WHAT DOES “PURSUING SOMEONE” ACTUALLY MEAN?

This one apparently needs its own seminar.

Because somehow we've reached a point where people think the only thing that counts as pursuing someone is asking:

“Will you be my girlfriend?”

No.

You can pursue somebody without ever using the word relationship.

If you consistently talk to someone because you're interested in them romantically, you're pursuing a connection.

If you're flirting with them because you're attracted to them, you're pursuing a connection.

If you're sending them sexual messages because you want sexual intimacy with them, you're pursuing something.

If you're exchanging nudes because you're sexually interested in each other, you're pursuing something.

If you're deliberately arranging to meet because you want to explore the attraction between you, you're pursuing something.

If you're going on dates with them, you're obviously exploring the possibility of something.

If you kiss them?

Baby.

What exactly do we think we're doing?

Attending a networking event?

You are pursuing something.

Now, pursuing someone does not mean you're in a relationship with them.

It doesn't even mean you'll end up together.

They might reject you.

You might meet and realise the chemistry isn't there.

You might go on three dates and decide you don't want a fourth.

You might sleep together and realise you don't want anything beyond that.

The outcome can be uncertain.

The pursuit is still happening.

And I think that's an important distinction because sometimes we act as though something only "counts" if it eventually becomes a relationship.

It doesn't.

You can pursue a person without committing to them.

You can explore an attraction without promising a future.

You can be sexually interested in someone without wanting to date them.

You can date someone casually without wanting them to become your partner.

Those things are all possible.

But if you're actively doing those things with specific people, you're not merely "open to options."

You're exploring options.

And there is a difference.

"I'M OPEN TO OPTIONS"

This phrase deserves scrutiny.

Because "I'm open to options" can mean:

"I don't want to commit yet."

And that's perfectly legitimate.

But it can also become a wonderfully convenient sentence for people who don't want to disclose what they're actually doing.

There is a difference between:

"I don't know whether I want a relationship right now."

and:

"I am currently talking to several people, arranging dates, flirting, exchanging sexual content and exploring multiple connections."

If you're doing the second thing, perhaps say the second thing.

Nobody is asking for a PowerPoint presentation.

You don't have to say:

"Her name is Brenda. She is 26. We met on Bumble on Tuesday. She likes chapati and has two sisters."

Nobody needs all that.

Sometimes the relevant information is simply:

"I'm seeing other people too."

That's it.

Now everyone understands the situation a little better.

SEX CHANGES THE CONVERSATION

And this is where I think people sometimes underestimate the importance of transparency.

If you're sexually involved with multiple people, that information can become relevant to the people you're sleeping with.

Not because sex makes someone morally better or worse.

Because sexual health exists.

Condom use exists.

STI testing exists.

Boundaries exist.

People have different comfort levels around sexual exclusivity, even when they aren't looking for romantic exclusivity.

Someone might be perfectly comfortable dating someone who is seeing other people.

Someone else might not be.

Someone might say, "That's fine, just use protection."

Someone else might say, "I'm not comfortable having unprotected sex in that arrangement."

Those are decisions people should be allowed to make with accurate information.

You don't need to provide someone's medical history.

You don't need to give a detailed account of every sexual encounter you've ever had.

But if your sexual situation has changed in a way that affects another person's ability to make an informed decision, pretending nothing has changed isn't exactly great communication.

AND YES, KISSING COUNTS

People love pretending kissing doesn't count because apparently we need a United Nations summit before we can determine whether putting your mouth on another person's mouth is intimate.

Please.

Kissing someone can be romantic.

It can be sexual.

It can mean absolutely nothing to one person and a lot to another.

The point isn't that kissing automatically violates every relationship boundary.

The point is that different people have different boundaries.

If you've agreed that kissing other people is fine, then fine.

If you haven't discussed it, don't assume everyone has the same definition of what "seeing other people" includes.

Sometimes the smallest sentence can prevent a very large misunderstanding.

SITUATIONSHIPS

Then there are situationships.

My favourite modern invention.

A relationship with enough emotional intimacy to require a PowerPoint presentation but apparently not enough definition to require a conversation.

You talk every day.

You sleep together.

You spend weekends together.

You know each other's family drama.

You know their coffee order.

You know their childhood trauma.

You have inside jokes.

You might even have a toothbrush at their house.

And then somebody asks:

"So, what are you two?"

And suddenly everyone develops amnesia.

"We're just seeing where things go."

Okay.

Where?

North?

South?

The International Space Station?

Situationships aren't inherently bad.

Sometimes people genuinely don't know what they want yet.

Sometimes two people are happy keeping things undefined.

The problem begins when both people are operating under completely different assumptions.

One person thinks, "We're casually seeing each other."

The other thinks, "We're basically exclusive, we're just not using the word."

That is how you end up with somebody saying:

"But I thought we were together."

And somebody else responding:

"But we never said we were."

Which brings us back to the beginning.

RELATIONSHIP ANARCHY

Relationship anarchy takes the idea of questioning traditional relationship rules even further.

Instead of assuming that romantic relationships automatically come with a standard hierarchy or a fixed set of expectations, people decide what each individual relationship means to them.

The relationship doesn't have to follow the traditional script.

There doesn't have to be an automatic progression from dating to exclusivity to marriage.

People can decide what they actually want instead of inheriting a relationship template simply because that's what society expects.

Again, this isn't a free pass to avoid communication.

If anything, when you remove the default rules, communication becomes even more important.

SOLO POLYAMORY

Solo polyamory generally describes people who practise polyamory while maintaining a strong sense of independence.

They may have multiple relationships but don't necessarily want the traditional escalator of moving in together, combining finances or becoming someone's primary domestic partner.

They can have meaningful relationships without making romantic partnership the centre of their entire life structure.

And honestly, there is something useful about understanding that distinction.

A relationship doesn't have to become a conventional household to be real.

HIERARCHICAL POLYAMORY

Hierarchical polyamory involves relationships that have different levels of priority or commitment.

For example, someone may have a primary partner and other secondary relationships.

This isn't automatically unfair or deceptive.

The relevant question is whether the people involved know what the hierarchy is and have consented to it.

Because imagine believing you're building a certain kind of relationship with someone only to discover six months later that there were rules about your relationship that everyone knew except you.

That would be a communication problem, not a polyamory problem.

PARALLEL POLYAMORY

Parallel polyamory is another arrangement where people may have multiple relationships without necessarily wanting those partners deeply involved in one another's lives.

You know about the other relationships.

You simply don't need to become best friends with everybody.

And honestly, fair enough.

Knowing about someone's other partner does not mean you need to be invited to their birthday dinner.

KITCHEN-TABLE POLYAMORY

Kitchen-table polyamory is almost the opposite.

The idea is that the different people connected through the relationship network may be comfortable interacting with one another.

They might sit around the same table.

They might become friends.

They might attend events together.

Nobody has to pretend the other people don't exist.

Different structure.

Different boundaries.

Same underlying requirement:

Everyone knows what they're participating in.

SWINGING

Swinging generally involves couples or people engaging in consensual sexual experiences with others, often together or within agreed boundaries.

Again, there are different versions of it.

Some couples may only do it together.

Some may have specific rules about who they can interact with.

Some may have boundaries around emotional involvement.

The details vary.

But nobody should have to discover halfway through that they accidentally joined a swinging arrangement.

There should probably be a conversation first.

Just a thought.

PRIVACY IS NOT THE SAME AS SECRECY

And this is probably the part I care about most.

Because I don't think honesty means giving someone unrestricted access to every corner of your life.

You are allowed to have privacy.

You don't have to hand over your phone.

You don't have to provide screenshots of every conversation.

You don't have to name every person who has ever flirted with you.

You don't have to give a detailed itinerary of your evening.

Privacy is healthy.

Secrecy is different.

Secrecy becomes a problem when information is deliberately withheld because revealing it might affect the other person's decision to continue participating.

And I learned that distinction in a very personal way.

I was involved with someone who had made it clear that we were not in a traditional relationship.

And I was okay with that.

I wasn't sitting there secretly demanding a relationship while pretending I was fine.

I understood that neither of us had promised exclusivity.

So if he wanted to meet other people, talk to other people, date other people or explore other connections, that was his choice.

I wasn't asking for control over that.

What I wanted was honesty about the reality I was participating in.

At one point, I found out that he was interacting with other women in ways I hadn't known about.

There were things I learned later that I wish I had simply been told.

And yes, I invaded privacy at one point because someone told me something and I wanted to confirm it.

I'm not proud of that.

But it also made me realise something.

I wasn't looking for every detail.

I wasn't trying to collect evidence.

I wasn't asking for names, screenshots, timestamps and a witness statement.

I simply wanted enough information to decide what I was comfortable participating in.

Because those are two very different things.

You get to choose what you do.

I get to choose what I participate in.

Those choices can coexist.

You can decide that you want to date five people.

I can decide that I'm comfortable seeing you while you date five people.

Or I can decide that I'm not.

You don't have to become monogamous because I don't like non-monogamy.

And I don't have to participate in something because you don't see a problem with it.

That's the beauty of informed choice.

THE ACTUAL POINT

I don't think the answer to modern dating is making everyone choose one relationship structure.

I think the answer is making people communicate clearly enough that everyone involved knows what they are agreeing to.

Say what you want.

Say what you don't want.

Say whether you're seeing other people.

Say whether you're sexually involved with other people when that information is relevant.

Say whether you're looking for a relationship, casual dating, something open-ended or absolutely nothing serious.

If you're unsure, say you're unsure.

"I don't know what I want yet" is a perfectly respectable answer.

It might not give the other person the certainty they want, but at least it gives them something real to work with.

And if your situation changes, communicate that too.

Because consent isn't just about agreeing to sex.

It is also about having enough information to decide whether you want to remain in the situation you're in.

That doesn't require constant reporting.

It doesn't require surveillance.

It doesn't require knowing every detail.

It requires honesty about the things that materially affect the relationship you're actually having.

MAYBE WE JUST NEED TO TALK

Modern dating isn't necessarily confusing because there are too many relationship structures.

It's confusing because we keep expecting people to understand arrangements that we've never actually discussed.

We say:

"I'm open."

"I'm seeing where things go."

"I'm not looking for anything serious."

"I'm keeping my options open."

"We're just talking."

And sometimes those sentences mean exactly what they sound like.

Sometimes they are intentionally vague.

And sometimes two people hear the exact same sentence and construct completely different realities around it.

That's where the problems begin.

You don't need to know exactly what your relationship will look like five years from now.

You don't need a label on the first date.

You don't need to promise marriage because you kissed someone.

You don't need to become exclusive because you slept together.

You don't need to be monogamous if monogamy doesn't work for you.

You don't need to be non-monogamous because everyone else seems to be experimenting.

But you do need to communicate.

Talk before you touch.

Talk before you promise.

Talk before you sleep together.

Talk before you start building emotional intimacy.

Talk when something changes.

And if you genuinely don't know what you want, say that.

The least we can do is actually use the words.

Because there is nothing wrong with wanting different things.

There is something deeply unfair about making someone participate in a reality they didn't know they were agreeing to.